

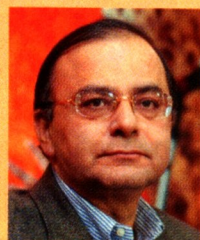
GANG OF MODI

THE TEAM THAT FORMS THE BRAIN BEHIND THE MASTER STRATEGIST

There's only one visible face of BJP and that is Narendra Modi himself. He is the mastermind working behind the scenes and is the chief executor at every campaign rally. The party has however deputed a few leaders to help him out. BJP general secretary Arun Jaitley leads the election gang that is managing Modi's media show at a time when the Press is ranged against the chief minister. It's a mix of local talent with Delhi-based professionals who are helping Jaitley run the show. These include Manish Bharadia, television professional and members of the Gujarat media cell.

The group's biggest coup is that it has managed to use a loophole in the law to run an independent channel that focusses solely on Modi's accomplishments. Called Vande Gujarat, this is run with the help of local channel operators. Its sole aim, according to a strategist, is to neutralise the impact of the Delhi-based print media. The Modi channel is web cast on the Internet from where channel operators download it and telecast it therefore no law can stop it. Its impact can be gauged from the fact that about 15 lakh people see this channel everyday and when Modi's speeches are shown live, the viewership doubles.

Another big hit is the Modi mask designed by Manish Bharadia. The mask is worn by Modi supporters so that the chief minister's presence can be felt in places even where he is not present. He also designed the website for BJP's



ARUN JAITLEY:
Spin doctor
and election
strategist



YAMEL VYAS:
Sells pro-Modi
propaganda to
local media



S.R. YADAV:
Cyber talent
who put Modi
on YouTube



**MANISH
BHARADIA:** The
man behind the
Modi mask

poll theme "Jeetega Gujarat" which received two lakh hits in just four days. This group meets everyday at 11.30 a.m. at BJP headquarters in Ahmedabad to assess the situation based on media inputs and then fashions a response by consulting Modi. For example, to counter the Congress campaign attacking him as a 'merchant of death', the team crafted an ad that said, "The society needs both security and development... rest assured I will not allow the merchants of death on the land of Gujarat, whatever the cost I have to pay."

Helping the group with grassroots-level inputs are BJP state media cell convener Yamal Vyas and member Shashiranjana Yadav. In fact Yadav is Modi's cyber hand having designed the party's hi-tech poll campaign. He has even put Modi on YouTube and Orkut and maintains a steady flow of catchy pro Modi SMS'. State party treasurer Surendra Patel's team has designed eight different cut-outs of Modi wearing different outfits, appealing to different regions and castes in the states. For instance, the one designed for tribal regions shows him in tribal wear while another for the Ahir-dominated area shows him in the dress of the Ahirs. At the ground level, it is state BJP general secretary Vijay Rupani who has reorganised 39,800 poll booth committees. Modi loyalists like state ministers Anandiben Patel, Amit Shah, I.K. Jadeja and Saurabh Patel are too busy fighting their own election to help in other areas. After all the victory of each is imperative for Modi's prestige.

by Uday Mahurkar

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STRAINED TIES: Suresh Mehta (left) with Keshu Bhai Patel

Sita abducted by Ravan?" "Yes." "Did Ram go to Lanka to free her?" "Yes." "Did Ram use that bridge across the sea to reach Lanka?" "Yes." "You say yes but the Congress says no..." When it comes to development, he twists the hand of Congress with such rhetorical relish. "The hand of Congress is like the one at a traffic junction. It stops development."

It can't stop me—that is the abiding attitude of Modi on the stump. I'll come back, he tells you, like a "steamroller" which no hand can dare to bring to a halt. Those who suffer from too much Modi may say this is arrogance, a word that comes easily to even some of his admirers. Narendrabhai can be defeated by only Modi, a me-alone maximum leader in the making. The me-alone part is all over the place. Modi is never seen in the company of the parivar grandies on the campaign posters. As Force Modi was concentrating the mass mind, elsewhere in the battlefield, the *maha yatri* of the party was looking for a crowd worthy of his reputation, but L.K. Advani never got one. That didn't stop BJP from sending some of its star performers like Sushma Swaraj, Smriti Irani, Venkaiah Naidu (possibly for alliterating comic relief) and Navjot Sidhu to Gujarat. They could not have added much to the show that was essentially conceived and choreographed by one man. Modi has colonised the space between anxiety and adoration. His absolute control in